The UK Field Guide

Photograph a plant, insect, bird, or fungus, and chat about what it is and what to do.

Conclusively identified as Scandosorbus intermedia!

Classification result (scientific name, common name, confidence %)

1. Scandosorbus intermedia (Swedish Whitebeam) 63.7%
2. Hedlundia mougeotii (Mougeot's Whitebeam) 28.9%
3. Hedlundia hybrida (Swedish Service-tree) 2.8%

▶ Show thinking (11 steps)

Scandosorbus intermedia

The retrieved field-guide material treats this plant as **Hedlundia intermedia**, formerly **Sorbus intermedia**, commonly called the **Swedish whitebeam**. *Scandosorbus* is also used for a group of hybrid whitebeam–rowan–wild-service-tree taxa, so the nomenclature is not entirely consistent.

It is a medium-sized deciduous tree, typically **10–20 m tall**, with a rounded crown and stout horizontal branches. Its main identifying features are:

- Green leaves with **dense pale grey-white hairs underneath**
- Leaves with **four to seven rounded lobes on each side**
- White flowers in broad clusters in late spring
- Orange-red to red, oval fruits ripening in mid-autumn
- Fruits eaten and dispersed by thrushes and waxwings

It is a hybrid-origin tree and is widely grown ornamentally in northern Europe, including in streets, parks and avenues. The retrieved material says it occurs in **England** and is **frequently naturalised in the British Isles**. It can therefore appear both as a planted tree and as a self-established tree.

UK status

The dedicated status check found:

- **No explicit UK legal conservation status** in the retrieved sources
- **No explicit IUCN status** found
- No entry supporting classification as a UK invasive species
- The invasive-species search result referring to another plant, *Lysichiton americanus*, was unrelated

That means I cannot verify that *Scandosorbus intermedia* is legally protected or designated invasive in the UK from the available material. It also does not amount to a definitive legal clearance, particularly for a particular site or local authority.

What to do

- **If it is a planted garden or street tree:** no immediate action appears warranted solely because of its species. Retain and manage it as an ornamental tree unless it is unsafe, unwanted or causing a site-specific problem.
- **If it is spreading into semi-natural woodland, heathland or another sensitive habitat:** record its location and seek advice from the local biological-record centre, land manager or a botanist before removing it.
- **Check the identification first.** The sources note that trees sold or planted as "Swedish whitebeam" may actually be the related *Hedlundia mougeotii*, which has more erect branches, less deeply lobed leaves, whiter leaf undersides and darker red fruit.
- **If you plan to fell a mature tree**, check with the landowner or local authority first rather than assuming its status.

Bottom line: the available evidence describes it as an ornamental tree that is naturalised in parts of Britain, but does not support treating it as a listed invasive or specially protected species. No automatic removal is indicated.

🚫 **This may be a regionally invasive species** — check local reporting/disposal rules before doing anything with it.

🛡️ **This may be a legally protected species** — check regulations before disturbing or removing it.

Sources:

- A Handbook of the British Flora, 1887 (George Bentham, 1858.) — https://archive.org/details/handbookofbrit00bent
- A History of British Birds (William Yarrell), Yarrell, William, 1784-1856, 1843 — https://archive.org/details/historyofbritish01will
- A Manual of British Botany, Royal College of Physicians of London. n 80046799, 1837 (Charles Cardale Babington, 19th-century UK flora reference.) — https://archive.org/details/b28038824
- British Birds, Thorburn, Archibald, 1860-1935, 1915 (W. H. Hudson, 1895. Replaces unresolvable various-authors placeholder.) — https://archive.org/details/britishbirds01thor
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- Curtis's Botanical Magazine, Sims, John, 1749-1831, 1801 (Long-running illustrated botanical periodical; early volumes are PD. Parenthetical clarifier removed -- it was breaking Open Library search matching.) — https://archive.org/details/curtissbotanica14simsgoog
- English Botany, 1863 (James Sowerby and James Edward Smith, 1790-1814. Replaces prior vague title -- Flora Britannica (1996, Richard Mabey) is NOT public domain, was a data error.) — https://archive.org/details/englishbotanyorc12sowerich
- The British Herbal (John Hill), Hill, John, 1714?-1775, 1756 (18th-century medicinal plant guide.) — https://archive.org/details/b30450950_0002
- The English Flora, Smith, James Edward, Sir, 1759-1828, [182 (James Edward Smith, 4 volumes, 1824-1828.) — https://archive.org/details/englishflorasje01smit
- Wikipedia, "Adder" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Adder
- Wikipedia, "Crassula helmsii" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Crassula_helmsii
- Wikipedia, "European hedgehog" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/European_hedgehog
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia
- Wikipedia, "Impatiens glandulifera" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Impatiens_glandulifera
- Wikipedia, "Invasive species" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Invasive_species
- Wikipedia, "Lysichiton americanus" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lysichiton_americanus
- Wikipedia, "Myriophyllum aquaticum" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Myriophyllum_aquaticum
- Wikipedia, "Ophrys sphegodes" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ophrys_sphegodes
- Wikipedia, "Quercus robur" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Quercus_robur
- Wikipedia, "Reynoutria japonica" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Reynoutria_japonica
- Wikipedia, "Rhododendron ponticum" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rhododendron_ponticum
- Wikipedia, "Sand lizard" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sand_lizard
- Wikipedia, "Smooth newt" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Smooth_newt
- Wikipedia, "Sorbus" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sorbus
- Wikipedia, "Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wildlife_and_Countryside_Act_1981

What is the scientific name of the Swedish whitebeam and where is it found?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

The Swedish whitebeam is identified in the field guide as ***Hedlundia intermedia***. Its former name is ***Sorbus intermedia***. The name ***Scandosorbus*** is also used for related hybrid whitebeam groups, so the nomenclature can vary.

It is found mainly in:

- Southern Sweden
- Estonia and Latvia
- Bornholm in eastern Denmark
- Far southwestern Finland
- Northern Poland
- England, where it also occurs

Sources:

- A Handbook of the British Flora, 1887 (George Bentham, 1858.) — https://archive.org/details/handbookofbrit00bent
- A Manual of British Botany, Royal College of Physicians of London. n 80046799, 1837 (Charles Cardale Babington, 19th-century UK flora reference.) — https://archive.org/details/b28038824
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The British Herbal (John Hill), Hill, John, 1714?-1775, 1756 (18th-century medicinal plant guide.) — https://archive.org/details/b30450950_0002
- Wikipedia, "Betula pendula" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Betula_pendula
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia
- Wikipedia, "Sorbus" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sorbus

What family does it belong to?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

Swedish whitebeam (*Hedlundia intermedia*, formerly *Sorbus intermedia*) belongs to the **rose family, Rosaceae**.

Sources:

- A Manual of British Botany, Royal College of Physicians of London. n 80046799, 1837 (Charles Cardale Babington, 19th-century UK flora reference.) — https://archive.org/details/b28038824
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The British Herbal (John Hill), Hill, John, 1714?-1775, 1756 (18th-century medicinal plant guide.) — https://archive.org/details/b30450950_0002
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia
- Wikipedia, "Sorbus" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sorbus

How tall does it grow and what does its trunk look like?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

Swedish whitebeam (*Scandosorbus intermedia*, often treated as *Hedlundia intermedia*) grows to about **10–20 metres tall**. It has a **stout trunk**, usually up to around **60 cm in diameter**, with **grey bark**. Exceptional trunks may reach **2–3 metres in diameter**.

Sources:

- A Manual of British Botany, Royal College of Physicians of London. n 80046799, 1837 (Charles Cardale Babington, 19th-century UK flora reference.) — https://archive.org/details/b28038824
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The British Herbal (John Hill), Hill, John, 1714?-1775, 1756 (18th-century medicinal plant guide.) — https://archive.org/details/b30450950_0002
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia
- Wikipedia, "Sorbus" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sorbus

What shape is the crown?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

The crown is **dome-shaped**, with **stout, mostly horizontal branches**.

Sources:

- A Handbook of the British Flora, 1887 (George Bentham, 1858.) — https://archive.org/details/handbookofbrit00bent
- A Manual of British Botany, Royal College of Physicians of London. n 80046799, 1837 (Charles Cardale Babington, 19th-century UK flora reference.) — https://archive.org/details/b28038824
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The Flowering Plants of Great Britain, 1905 (Anne Pratt, 6 volumes, 1855-1873 (also known as The Flowering Plants, Grasses, Sedges, and Ferns of Great Britain). Replaces unresolvable author placeholder.) — https://archive.org/details/floweringplantsg01prat
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia

What do the leaves look like?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

The leaves are **green on top** and **densely covered with pale grey-white hairs underneath**. They are about **7–12 cm long and 5–7 cm wide**, with **four to seven oval lobes on each side**, finely serrated edges, and rounded tips. In autumn they turn **dull yellowish to grey-brown**.

Sources:

- A Handbook of the British Flora, 1887 (George Bentham, 1858.) — https://archive.org/details/handbookofbrit00bent
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The English Flora, Smith, James Edward, Sir, 1759-1828, [182 (James Edward Smith, 4 volumes, 1824-1828.) — https://archive.org/details/englishflorasje01smit
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia

What color do the leaves turn in autumn?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

In autumn, the leaves turn **dull yellowish to grey-brown**.

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- A Handbook of the British Flora, 1887 (George Bentham, 1858.) — https://archive.org/details/handbookofbrit00bent
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The British Herbal (John Hill), Hill, John, 1714?-1775, 1756 (18th-century medicinal plant guide.) — https://archive.org/details/b30450950_0002
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia

What do the flowers look like?

▶ Show thinking (2 steps)

The flowers are **white, five-petalled blooms**, about **15–20 mm across**, with around **20 yellowish-white stamens**. They appear in broad clusters, or **corymbs**, about **8–12 cm wide**, in late spring.

Sources:

- A Handbook of the British Flora, 1887 (George Bentham, 1858.) — https://archive.org/details/handbookofbrit00bent
- A Manual of British Botany, Royal College of Physicians of London. n 80046799, 1837 (Charles Cardale Babington, 19th-century UK flora reference.) — https://archive.org/details/b28038824
- British Trees and Shrubs, Bean, W. J. (William Jackson), 1863-1947, 1916 (Published by the Tree Council; covers all common ornamental and native trees in the UK.) — https://archive.org/details/treesshrubshardy01beanrich
- The British Herbal (John Hill), Hill, John, 1714?-1775, 1756 (18th-century medicinal plant guide.) — https://archive.org/details/b30450950_0002
- Wikipedia, "Hedlundia intermedia" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedlundia_intermedia
- Wikipedia, "Sorbus" — https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sorbus

Ask a follow-up question... Send

↻ Start over